

and unreliable, while Flash drives are limited in size. But what if mobiles could have laptop-sized storage devices? Say, 100 GB? Enter nanotechnology, promising to revolutionise storage. With compact mobile devices, such as phones, what's required is tiny drives with large data densities that work on little or no power. Research underway in the UK—Imperial College London, Sheffield, and Durham universities, to be precise—has yielded prototypes of an entirely new chip design that mimics the way the

human brain stores data. At the nanoscale, they've recreated the axon-neuron pattern of the human brain—a complex mesh of nanowires that perform computing functions at the nodes where the nanowires meet. We cannot explain it in detail in this space, but you can read more at <http://tinyurl.com/2u9qxp>.

The bottom-line of all this is that we foresee mobile phones becoming very pocket-able mobile computing devices, which can also make calls—as an afterthought. ☒

Prosumerism



Illustration Shrikrishna Patkar

If you don't like what's available, make one...

There are three ways to define "Prosumer": for the consumer, the professional consumer, and the producer / consumer. For the consumer, "the customer is always right" is the attitude a lot of companies adhere to, and that's the end of that. What interests us more in terms of future trends—and sets our Sixth Sense a-tingling—is the professional consumers and the producer / consumers.

Professional Consumers

Those of you old enough to remember things the way they were a decade or two ago should think back to the way technology was bought, the way it was advertised. Because of the use of marketing gimmicks, fights for price, useless TLAs, even the love of your country in "be Indian, buy Indian" type ads, you could tell that the brands considered the Indian consumer to be, well, dumb. Be honest: how many of you knew how TVs worked, or even used a computer more than a decade ago? There was no Net, there was no trillion-dollar IT industry, and engineers and doctors got the best marriage proposals!

Fast-forward to today, and you see features and more features. You see ads for any sort of electronic device—from a TV to the iPhone—with all the specifications that can be crammed into the space. Have you seen LCD ads? They expect you to know what HDMI stands for; ditto for HDTV, 720p, the difference between "p" and "i" and other such indecipherable jargon. Ads for speaker sets have started telling you about watts per channel in RMS, not PMPO as it was done before—well, most speaker sets anyway. The bottom-line is that manufacturers know their target audience is well-informed.

How Did This Happen?

Thanks to computers, the Net, the infiltration of technology into everyday life, and maga-

